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Since 1975, when this magazine was founded, it has accompanied more than a couple of generations of Indians along a tumultuous and exciting journey for the greater part of our country's history as an independent nation. Now, on the cusp of our 50th year in print, you'll understand the impulse to look back with a range of emotions. The nostalgia goes without saying, but in compiling this special selection of 50 'turning points' in the back pages of India and INDIA TODAY, we have focused on events and episodes that caught our collective imagination or national sentiment. They range from civic milestones like the Right to Information Act of 2005 to fanciful beauty pageant victories of 1994. From the grim triumph of Kargil in 1999 to the giddy cricketing world cup victory of 1983.

Each of these events have profoundly shaped the country and their impact continues to be felt in myriad ways. Of course, not every major event in these past decades has come to good nor every lesson been learnt. We are a work in progress, after all, with no Fukuyamian end to our history in sight—nor would we want that prospect! And while we have omitted some of these darker chapters from this anniversary almanac, it does consider some salutary milestones when tragedies or even terrible crimes galvanised Indians to do better—or at least to try.

Think of these pages as a mirror—yes, one of glossy paper, but an inspiring one all the same.

Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**